

When the gut is on high alert

Understanding symptom hypervigilance — and gentle ways to turn the volume down.

Hypervigilance is when the nervous system starts closely monitoring the gut, scanning for the next symptom. It's a protective response — but when it runs in overdrive, the very act of watching makes sensations feel louder and more frequent.

The amplification loop

Symptoms and worry can feed each other in a self-reinforcing cycle:

- 1 You **notice** a gut sensation
- 2 You **worry** about what it means
- 3 Worry raises **tension** and arousal in the body
- 4 Tension **amplifies** the sensation — and attention narrows back onto it

This is not a character flaw or a lack of willpower. It's a nervous system doing its job a little too well. The good news: the loop can be softened.

Gentle ways to turn the volume down

- **Broaden your attention.** Deliberately widen focus to sounds, surroundings or a task, rather than scanning the gut.
- **Name it.** "This is hypervigilance, not danger." Naming the process reduces its grip.
- **Regulate first.** A slow, extended out-breath tells the body it's safe (see the regulation basics sheet).
- **Ease the checking.** Constant body-scanning and reassurance-seeking feel helpful but keep the loop alive — reduce them gradually, with support.

A tool to carry: S.H.F.T.™

When a wave hits: **Stop** · **Hold** (steady the breath) · **Focus** (widen attention) · **Take Action** (a small, values-based next step). A pocket reset for high-alert moments.

Turning the volume down is not about ignoring your body or pushing through pain. It's about helping an over-protective system learn that it can stand down.

This sheet is general information — not a diagnosis or a substitute for medical care. EF Health psychological support works alongside your medical team, never instead of it. If your symptoms are new, severe, or changing, please speak with your GP or specialist.

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